

About: topics and movement

Teaching guide

Use about for a topic and recognize its other meanings.

Understand the distinction

About often means on the subject of: talk about a film, think about a question, read about a place. It does not automatically make an action longer or more detailed.

Verb patterns differ. Discuss normally takes its topic directly: discuss the plan. Talk usually needs about before a topic. About can also mean approximately or around a place: about ten minutes; walk about the room.

Compare the patterns

TOPIC

We talked about the trip.

The trip is the subject of the conversation.

DIRECT OBJECT

We discussed the trip.

No about is needed in this pattern.

AROUND

She walked about the room.

About describes movement around a place.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. Choose the correction: We discussed about the price.

- A. We discussed the price.
- B. We discussed on the price.
- C. We discussed to the price.

2. Does think about tell us how long someone thinks?

- A. Yes. It means thinking for a long time.
- B. Yes. It means thinking briefly.
- C. No. It introduces the topic.

3. What does about mean in about twenty people?

- A. Fewer than.
- B. Approximately.
- C. Exactly.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Which pair correctly introduces the topic after talk and after discuss?

- A. We talked about the schedule. We discussed a possible change.
- B. We talked about the schedule. We discussed about a possible change.
- C. We talked about the schedule. We discussed to a possible change.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. We discussed the price.

Discuss takes a direct object for its topic.

B: Discuss takes its topic directly: discussed the price.

C: Do not insert to between discuss and its topic.

2. C. No. It introduces the topic.

Duration needs additional context, such as for ten minutes.

A: About identifies the topic, not the amount of time spent thinking.

B: The phrase does not specify how long the thinking lasts.

3. B. Approximately.

This is a quantity meaning, not a topic.

A: About means approximately; the number could be a little higher or lower.

C: About makes the number approximate, rather than exact.

4. A. We talked about the schedule. We discussed a possible change.

Talked about uses about; discussed takes its topic directly.

B: Discuss normally takes its topic directly, without about.

C: Do not add to between discussed and the topic.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-07.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Which pair correctly introduces the topic after talk and after discuss?

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.